complex; Russia's deepening reliance on China as a strategic partner when Sino-Indian ties are themselves imperilled; and Russia's continuing enervation as a great power, which undermines India's desire for global multipolarity. If more Russian reverses in Ukraine precipitate nuclear weapons use—an unlikely but nevertheless plausible prospect—India's ties with Russia will be threatened dangerously, given Putin's already clear disregard of Prime Minister Narendra Modi's appeals for an end to the conflict.

Furthermore, the dangers of a global economic crisis persist and could produce discomfiting headwinds for India at a time when its own post-pandemic economic recovery has just begun. The problems of worldwide inflation promise to endure for a while longer, with baleful consequences for India's import bill. Any sudden escalation in the Ukraine conflict could also send energy prices skyrocketing again as well as increase the cost of fertilisers, both of which matter disproportionately for India's macroeconomic stability. China's about-turn in its Covid management strategy also promises dramatically increased domestic infection rates, which only guarantee further global supply chain disruptions. These will affect India, too, given its substantial, and even increasing, dependence on Chinese inputs for a wide range of industries, from drugs to electronics and telecommunications. And a global recession, if that comes to pass, or even the almost inevitable economic slowdown, will constrain Indian exports, which remain a critical driver of India's economic growth. In many ways, then, India's return to higher growth is still shadowed by diverse storm clouds that will not disappear in the current year—and the challenges could, in fact, be exacerbated if the Modi government pursues increased politically-motivated redistributionism in anticipation of the 2024 national election.

Finally, India's immediate threat environment promises to remain just as unsettled in 2023 as it was during the past year. The situation in Pakistan remains deeply troubled, with no respite in sight. Although Islamabad's problems are largely internal, the possibility of a pernicious spillover to India cannot be discounted. Sino-Pakistani strategic collaboration against India is also certain to intensify in more problematic ways at a time when the situation in Afghanistan, Sri Lanka and Burma remains disturbing. But, worst of all, despite China's increasing troubles with Covid at home, Beijing seems determined to sustain significant military pressure against India along its borders. Even if China finally completes the disengagement of forces from the last two disputed locations in eastern Ladakh, it is unlikely to withdraw the substantial combat forces it currently maintains along the frontiers to their peacetime locations. The burdens that this transformed Chinese military posture imposes on India, both financially and operationally, will therefore persist indefinitely.

> FOR INDIA, TESTING US FORBEARANCE IS **NOT A GREAT WAY TO DEEPEN STRATEGIC COOPERATION** BETWEEN THE TWO COUNTRIES

The year 2023, thus, begins on a bleak note where New Delhi is concerned. Yet there are glimmers of hope. The Indian economy remains a bright spot in an otherwise dreary landscape; India's domestic politics continues to be remarkably stable; and India's foreign relations, beyond its immediate neighbourhood, are in fine fettle. Moreover, US-Indian strategic ties continue to improve steadily. Joe Biden's administration has doubled down on India in ways that demonstrate strong continuity with the policy first inaugurated by George W. Bush. During India's G20 presidency, the United States will showcase this continued support of New Delhi in myriad ways, including through Biden's presence at the G20 summit later in the fall. Bilateral relations, therefore, will continue to expand in different ways, driven in part by the common interest in balancing China, even though the uncomfortable questions about India's democratic backsliding, its weakening liberal credentials and its neo-mercantilist attitudes to trade will persist—occasionally producing political reactions in Washington that will test the partnership.

But the biggest danger on this count currently is India's policy toward Russia and its aggression in Ukraine. New Delhi's approach of running with the hares and hunting with the hounds—delicately condemning Russia's onslaught even as it benefits from the consequences—has worked thus far because the Biden administration has chosen not to push back resolutely because of the convergent interests on China. Yet US discomfort with India's policy is real and is already taking a toll. Although senior officials have bent backwards to preserve the productive relationship with New Delhi, the sympathy for India in other parts of the US government—where critical choices involving cooperation are assessed and triaged—is increasingly taxed and could be imperilled. Testing American forbearance, therefore, is not a great way to deepen US-Indian strategic cooperation. At a time when both countries must cope with multiple crises, carefully nurturing the opportunities for more robust collaboration through a productive "exchange of considerations" becomes all the more pressing. ■